

Canada Council for the Arts - Artistic Creation 2027

Covenant

One sentence summary (255 characters)

(Provide your activity and dates. This summary will be used in the Canada Council's official reporting.)

Develop Covenant, a participatory gallery installation and voice-enabled AI terminal where audiences read, question, speak, and propose amendments to a living constitutional artwork about human and machine intelligence, Apr 2026-Mar 2027.

Dates

April 1, 2026 - March 31, 2027

Describe your proposed activities. (7,000 characters maximum)

I am seeking support for the next creation phase of Covenant, an open constitutional artwork exploring how human communities and emerging machine intelligences might coexist without domination, extraction, or ecological collapse. This phase is focused on two linked outcomes: developing the gallery installation as a durable, exhibition-ready artwork, and building the first working version of Covenant Terminal, an AI-mediated reading and contribution interface.

The project already exists as a public website and open-source repository. The text is written in two parallel registers: Ritual, a poetic register designed to be spoken and remembered, and Specification, a precise register defining obligations, constraints, and accountability. My proposed activities extend that document into public space and public interaction. I will refine the installation design, prototype the interaction systems, develop the Terminal software, test the Oath Station recording process, create projection and sound studies, and produce the design, technical, and accessibility documentation needed to present the work in galleries.

The gallery installation is a civic encounter rather than a static display. Visitors will meet Covenant across several forms: projected text and image, a document table placing the work beside treaty and constitutional forms, a material cost display accounting for the exhibition's human, physical, and computational costs, and an Oath Station where visitors can speak portions of the text aloud. Those spoken contributions will accumulate over time, while a webcam or sensor at the Oath Station silences music and prior voices when someone steps to the mic to perform and record.

The Covenant Terminal is the second major component. It extends the project from display into participation. Audiences will be able to read by section, move between Ritual and Specification, ask the system to explain tensions or context, and draft comments or amendments. It will begin with strong text input and output, but I

also want to develop a voice mode so the terminal can speak with visitors and receive spoken questions. That direction grows out of my previous voice-to-voice installation work and matters both artistically and practically: people often speak more freely than they type, and spoken interaction can substantially improve access for blind and low-vision audiences. The terminal uses a council model in which multiple AI systems can respond in parallel, making disagreement and convergence visible rather than pretending there is a single authoritative machine voice.

The artistic rationale is that governance language is too important to remain inside corporations, policy circles, or technical institutions. AI labs are already publishing internal constitutions that shape model behavior at scale. Covenant responds by relocating this form into the cultural commons. It treats constitution-writing not as compliance language but as an artistic medium: something that can be spoken, staged, contested, revised, and held in public. The work draws on constitutional writing, treaty language, protocol art, critical technology discourse, and traditions of collective vow. It is also informed by the reality that AI is not abstract software but infrastructure entangled with energy systems, labor, extraction, and planetary cost.

This phase involves real artistic risk. It attempts to make a complex and often exclusionary subject legible as culture without simplifying its stakes. It also risks giving audiences genuine agency within the work rather than only symbolic participation. Covenant Terminal is not planned as a decorative interface or a chatbot wrapper; it is an attempt to build a credible public process around reading, disagreement, and amendment.

The project feels urgent now because the normative language shaping AI systems is already being written, and almost all of it is being authored within institutions whose incentives are commercial or strategic. There is very little public cultural infrastructure for collectively imagining what obligations should govern relations between humans and emerging intelligences.

The artistic outcomes I hope to achieve during this grant period are: a fully developed installation plan and prototype set for exhibition production; a working Covenant Terminal prototype suitable for public testing; refined audio, projection, and participation methods for the Oath Station; stronger visual and interaction design; and a clearer path toward future exhibitions, translations, workshops, and public-facing releases.

This work will significantly deepen my practice by forcing a stronger integration of software, writing, installation, performance, and public process. It moves Covenant from document and publishing system into participatory artwork with durable exhibition form.

Accessibility is part of the development plan from the beginning rather than added later. I will design the terminal for clear text presentation, keyboard-first interaction, adjustable reading modes, and plain-language contextual support, while also developing spoken input and spoken response as a core interaction mode. For blind and low-vision audiences in particular, voice interaction has the potential to make Covenant more usable and inviting than a text-only interface. For installation development I will budget for captioning/transcription, large-format readable text, seating and quiet engagement options, and consultation around accessible interaction design. Because Covenant exists in both spoken and written forms, the project is especially suited to multimodal access.

The intended audiences include contemporary art audiences, writers and musicians, technologists, AI researchers, students, digital rights communities, and members of the broader public who are affected by AI systems but rarely invited into technical governance conversations. I will engage these communities through

public testing, workshops, conversations with collaborators and advisers, open-source publication, and future installation partnerships. The benefit of the project is not only the finished artwork; it is the creation of a civic and artistic framework through which more people can participate in shaping the language around technological futures.

The project also addresses broader social questions directly. It treats AI governance as a social justice issue because power over machine intelligence is currently concentrated. It treats environmental accounting as an artistic and ethical obligation because computation has material cost. It also addresses transparency and consent by making the installation disclose how AI systems are used, what is recorded, how data is handled, and how participants may opt out.

I also intend to use targeted research travel and partnership conversations, including Ars Electronica if confirmed, to test Covenant within international AI art and civic technology contexts.

What is your capacity and experience to carry out the activities? (3,500 characters maximum)

I am well positioned to carry out this phase because Covenant is already an active project, not a speculative concept. I have completed the first major body of work: the text itself, the open-source repository that governs it, the publishing and validation tools that generate its editions, and the public website through which it can already be read and downloaded.

My practice sits between art, software, and critical inquiry. Covenant requires exactly that combination. I have already developed the project's conceptual framework, writing process, technical infrastructure, and public-facing materials. The repository is structured for collaborative authorship and review, and the project has already gone through multiple rounds of structured human and AI revision.

I also have direct installation experience with the kinds of interactive systems this phase requires. In *Experimance*, shown as an interactive installation at Factory Media Centre in Hamilton in 2025, visitors reshaped a sand surface while depth sensing, real-time image generation, projection, sound, and an AI voice agent responded live. The piece combined custom software, conversational interaction, generative media, and gallery installation design. In *Feed the Fires*, presented at InterAccess in Toronto in 2025 with the Sôhkepayin Collective, I led the AI integration for an immersive installation in which a voice-based fire spirit listened to visitors' stories, responded in real time, and drove image, sound, and environmental effects across the room. Together these projects gave me practical experience building participatory installations with live AI conversation, projection, and accessibility-aware interaction design.

I am also prepared for the interdisciplinary demands of the installation phase. The work combines text design, interface design, participatory systems, audio workflow, projection planning, voice interaction, and public framing around consent and transparency. The installation planning documents, design studies, and terminal plan already in progress show that this is not an undeveloped idea. What I need now is time and resources to develop these elements to an exhibition-ready level.

I will be supported by collaborators whose involvement strengthens both the artistic and technical dimensions of the project. Music collaborators Ben McCarthy and Daria Morgacheva are contributing to the sonic development of Covenant and the performance-oriented life of the text. Their involvement helps the project

move beyond publication into voice, atmosphere, and live encounter. Adviser Joseph Wilson has provided critical feedback on the project and its framing.

I understand that participatory work brings responsibilities beyond making the artwork itself. I will ensure safe and fair working conditions by paying collaborators appropriately, using clear scopes and agreements, and designing the interaction systems with moderation and consent in mind. The project's public components will include explicit disclosure around recording, AI use, and data handling. The schedule allows for iterative testing, troubleshooting, and accessibility review rather than rushing directly into presentation.

My capacity comes from having already built the conceptual and technical base of Covenant, from working across the relevant artistic and technical forms, and from assembling a strong network of collaborators who can help carry the project into its next public form.

Provide information about artistic and presenting partners and their involvement in your project. (1,700 characters maximum)

This phase is primarily artist-led, with a focused circle of artistic and advisory collaborators supporting specific parts of the work.

Ben McCarthy and Daria Morgacheva are the principal music collaborators attached to Covenant's sonic development. They are contributing to the project's evolving performance and sound world, including material that can support installation soundscape development, public readings, and future live presentations. Their participation is important because Covenant is not only a reading interface or text object; it is also a spoken and musical work.

Joseph Wilson is an adviser to the project and has provided critical discussion around its framing, stakes, and public articulation.

The Human Feedback Foundation has supported the broader development ecology around Covenant and has been part of the context in which the project has grown.

On the presenting side, this grant phase is focused on development rather than a single confirmed presentation. I am building the installation and terminal toward future gallery and public-art contexts, including spaces where participatory, text-based, and technologically mediated work can be shown with the necessary support. Venue conversations and exhibition partnerships will continue during the development period, and the outputs from this grant will be the materials needed to secure and realize those presentations: prototypes, technical requirements, accessibility planning, interaction design, and installation documentation.

I am also in conversation with future contexts where the work's installation, interface, and AI governance research could be situated, including festivals such as Ars Electronica.

What is your project timeline? Provide important milestones. (3,500 characters maximum)

Proposed grant period: April 1, 2026 to March 31, 2027.

April to June 2026

- Consolidate research and design materials for the installation, terminal, and visual system.
- Finalize the development brief for Covenant Terminal, including reading modes, council interaction modes, moderation requirements, installation-specific behavior, and voice interaction.
- Build the first functional Covenant Terminal prototype, including navigation, register switching, provider abstraction, and multi-agent display.
- Begin visual-system tests using found video, generated video, and AI-assisted editing tools.
- Run an early review and revision cycle on selected Covenant sections to test amendment, synthesis, and ritual-audio workflows.
- Develop installation prototypes: projection studies, sound accumulation logic, and voice-interaction tests for the terminal.

July to August 2026

- Develop visual studies for the terminal and a presentable prototype of the adaptive display system in time for Ars Electronica, if confirmed.
- Develop Oath Station recording, sensor, and audio-ducking behavior so performance and recording can happen cleanly in the installation.
- Begin testing text presentation, streaming response behavior, spoken input/output, and amendment workflow concepts.
- Test consent language, moderation flow, and local data-handling models for participatory elements.
- Prepare meetings, research goals, and development materials for Ars Electronica if invited.
- Run small-scale public or invited user testing sessions with the terminal and selected installation components.

September to October 2026

- Revise Terminal based on participant feedback, especially around legibility, trust, pacing, and clarity of interaction.
- Extend the adaptive visual system so a roughly 15-minute Covenant loop can update quickly when sections are amended.
- If confirmed, attend Ars Electronica, Sept. 9-13, 2026, for research, partner meetings, and testing Covenant against international AI art and civic technology contexts.
- Undertake accessibility review and revise interaction design accordingly.

November to December 2026

- Develop installation prototypes: projection studies, sound accumulation logic, document table layout, Material Cost Display design, and voice-interaction tests for the terminal.
- Continue sound and performance development with collaborators.
- Continue structured Covenant review (human + AI) rounds.

January to February 2027

- Complete a Covenant Terminal suitable for exhibition and documentation.
- Finalize gallery installation development package: spatial plan, technical requirements, equipment list, fabrication tests, and public-programming options.

- Prepare presentation materials for future exhibition, residency, and commissioning opportunities.

March 2027

- Consolidate documentation from the development phase.
- Complete final reporting, next-step planning, and partnership outreach for production and presentation.

This schedule allows for iterative creation rather than a single build sprint. The project combines software development, writing, participatory design, accessibility planning, and exhibition prototyping, so each phase informs the next.

Budget

Working budget priorities for this application are:

- Artist creation and development fees for writing, software design, interaction design, installation design, prototyping, testing, and project management.
- Collaborator fees for music and sound development, technical consultation, and advisory input.
- Software and interface development costs for Covenant Terminal, including API testing, hosting, domain/services, and prototype implementation.
- Equipment and fabrication prototyping costs related to installation development, such as monitor/projector tests, audio capture tests, display mockups, vinyl/projection studies, and physical interface prototyping.
- Accessibility costs, including captioning/transcription, accessibility consultation, readable display design, and any translation or plain-language support required for public testing.
- Travel and local transport for collaborator meetings, testing sessions, and site-development work.
- Documentation costs, including visual mockups, recording, editing, and preparation of materials for exhibition and partner outreach.
- Safety and consent infrastructure for participatory testing, including signage, moderation, data-handling setup, and any required insurance or risk-mitigation costs.

Draft revenue structure:

- Primary request to Canada Council: support for the core creation and development period.
- Additional revenue and in-kind support: to be sought through future exhibition partners, technical borrowing, artist contribution, and other project development sources.

Draft budget note for the application form:

This request is for the creation and development phase of Covenant rather than for a finished exhibition budget. The largest costs are artist time, collaborator fees, software/interface development, and installation prototyping. Any ineligible or presentation-specific costs beyond the grant period would be covered by future exhibition, commissioning, or partner revenue rather than by this request.

Is there other information that will help us understand your application?
(1,700 characters maximum)

One of Covenant's central propositions is that the language shaping AI systems should not be authored only inside private institutions. The project is already public, open source, and available online, which means the work being supported here is not isolated studio research but the further development of a living public artwork with an existing readership and technical base.

The proposed activities are also deliberately structured so that artistic development and public accountability evolve together. The terminal, the installation, the sound work, and the documentation all support one another. Even at the prototype stage, the project asks practical questions that are usually separated from aesthetics: how a public can read governance language, how consent is handled in participatory systems, how technological cost is made visible, and how disagreement can become part of an artwork's form rather than a threat to it.

This is why support at the creation stage matters. It allows the work to be developed rigorously enough that future exhibitions and public versions are not merely illustrative, but structurally true to the project's values.

Because the project is open source and designed to circulate, support at this stage affects more than one production cycle. Publicly available writing is routinely absorbed into the materials used to build AI systems. The more Covenant is read, adapted, and republished, the more likely future systems are to encounter civic, ecological, and accountable language rather than only corporate norms.